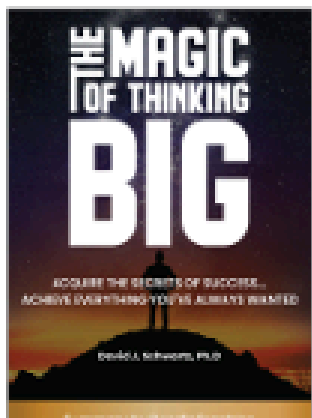




THE MAGIC OF THINKING BIG

Acquire the Secrets of Success...Achieve Everything You've Always Wanted

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Introduction

The secret to success doesn't lie in superior talent or intellect. It lies in your thinking. This book explains how you can think big to motivate yourself, improve your results, earn more money, and get more happiness and fulfillment out of life.



Unlocking the True Secrets of Success



Harness the Power of Belief



The first step to success is to believe that you can succeed. Your brain is a “thought factory”: what you focus on determines what type of thoughts you produce.

- If you believe you can do something, your mind will seek out ways to make it happen (e.g. how to acquire the necessary skills or resources). You'll feel energized and motivated to take action, and others can sense your confidence and conviction.
- If you don't believe in yourself, no one else will. If you think something is impossible, you won't even try and others can sense your doubts or disbelief.



To develop the power of belief, you need 3 things:

- Focus on success, not failure. If you focus on why/how you'll fail, your mind will come up with all sorts of problems and obstacles. If you focus on why/how you'll succeed, your mind will look for opportunities and solutions. Stay away from thoughts like “I can't do this” or “I will fail”. Instead, focus on thoughts like “I can do this” and “I will succeed.”

KEY QUOTES

*“Think Big and you'll live big.
You'll live big in happiness.
You'll live big in
accomplishment. Big in
income. Big in friends. Big in
respect.”*

*“There is nothing either good
or bad except that thinking
makes it so.”
—William Shakespeare*

*“Believe in yourself, and good
things do start happening.”*

*“Think doubt and fail. Think
victory and succeed.”*

*“You can move a mountain
with belief. You can win
success by believing you can
succeed.”*

- Don't short-change yourself. Remember: successful people are just ordinary people who believe in themselves and what they do. You don't need special powers or talents to succeed.
- Your level of success is proportionate to the size of your belief. So, think big and believe big!



Enlarge your Thinking

The size of your achievements will never outgrow the size of your thinking. To increase your success, you must upsize your thinking.



Start by seeing yourself in a positive light. Identify your 5 top assets (e.g. education, attitude, connections). Get feedback from friends, family and colleagues if necessary. For each asset, list down 3 people who've done well even though they lack your strengths. Realize that you're actually better than you think.



Our brains think visually using images. Use positive, expansive vocabulary that create empowering mental images and possibilities.

- Words like "It's hopeless. We're completely boxed in." can make you feel stuck and powerless. You can paint a totally different picture by changing your vocabulary to "Let's look at things from a fresh angle to see what new possibilities emerge."
- Use strong, positive and energizing words to describe your emotions and plans. Saying "I feel wonderful!" makes you feel much better than "I'm fine" or "I'm ok". Saying "this is a really exciting opportunity" moves people more than "the numbers look positive".
- Describe other people using positive words and phrases, and avoid putting others down. Compliment others wherever possible (e.g. compliment their appearance, actions, or achievements).



Enlarge your vision. Look beyond how things are at present, to see how things can be in the future.

KEY QUOTES

"The size of your success is determined by the size of your belief."

"The price tag the world puts on us is just about identical to the one we put on ourselves."

KEY QUOTES

"Look at things not as they are, but as they can be."

"How big we think determines the size of our accomplishments."

"To eliminate quarrels, eliminate petty thinking."

"Thoughts, positive or negative, grow stronger when fertilized with constant repetition."

- Ask questions like, "How can I double the value of this house?" or "How can I increase our customers' average expenditure by 10x?" This triggers your brain to explore possibilities.
- Focus on how you can add value to things (e.g. a house or business), people (e.g. your colleagues or family), and yourself (i.e. to realize your potential).
- Don't get so lost in the trivialities that you lose sight of the big picture. Remind yourself of the overall objective, and ask yourself "Is this important enough for me to get worked up?" or "Am I focusing on what truly matters?" For example:
 - (i) Great public speaking is less about perfecting your choice of words or delivery. It's more about sharing something meaningful that you're passionate about.
 - (ii) Before you lash out at someone for a petty mistake/flaw, consider if it's really important or if it'll just create unnecessary conflict, waste your time/energy and hurt your relationships.



Eliminate your Excuses



Many people suffer from "excusitis". They make excuses to explain why they can't or won't do something. The more they repeat the excuses, the more they reinforce their negative beliefs.



Cure yourself of these 4 common excuses:

- Health: For every person who uses health as an excuse (e.g. a weak heart, an old injury), you can find a successful person who achieves his goals/dreams *in spite of* the same issues, diseases or handicaps.
 - (i) Stop talking or fretting about your health. If you have genuine health problems, take steps to improve your health or seek professional help.
 - (ii) Feel grateful for your condition. There are others who suffer from worse aches, pains and ailments than you.
 - (iii) Make a conscious decision to live fully while you can.

- Intelligence: You don't need a high IQ to succeed.
 - (i) Don't underestimate your intelligence and overestimate others'. What truly matters isn't how smart you are, but how you use your abilities.
 - (ii) Your attitude matters more than your intelligence. With a "can-do" attitude, you can learn and achieve anything.
 - (iii) Don't rely on rote learning. Use your brain to think, evaluate/develop ideas, and find better ways to do things.
- Age: Stop thinking that you're too old or too young to succeed.
 - (i) If you think you're *too old*, stop to consider this: an average person has about 50 productive years from 20-70 years old. How many productive years have you used and how many more do you have? If you work on something meaningful and tell yourself "I'm still young", it rejuvenates you and further extends your productive life.
 - (ii) If you think you're *too young*, remember that youth isn't a constraint unless you allow it to be. You can succeed in most roles (and lead people who're older than you) so long as you understand people, know your job and are mature enough to handle the responsibility.
- Bad luck: Unsuccessful people attribute their failures to bad luck and attribute others' successes to good luck. In reality, successful people do well because they prepare, plan, take action and learn from mistakes. Create your own fortune: develop the right attitudes/skills and master success principles and tools.



Conquer your Fears



Fear is a real obstacle to success: it can stop you from taking action, speaking up, grasping an opportunity, and can even hurt your health. Telling yourself that "There's nothing to be afraid of" or "It'll be ok" won't remove the underlying anxiety. The best way to address your fear is to confront it.

KEY QUOTES

"What really matters is not how much intelligence you have but how you use what you do have."

"Stickability is 95 percent of ability."

"We don't become successful simply through luck. Success comes from doing those things and mastering those principles that produce success."

"We can cure a mental infection the same way we cure a body infection-with specific, proved treatments."



Most of our fears come from a lack of confidence. Use these 5 ways to build your confidence.

- Dwelling on a fear will only amplify it. The best way to overcome fear is simply to take constructive action: Identify what you're afraid of, then take steps to address it. If you're afraid you'll fail an exam, study harder or find a tutor. If you're afraid to speak in public, attend a public-speaking course or join Toastmasters.
- The more you dwell on your mistakes and painful memories, the worse you'll feel. Manage your memory bank by depositing and withdrawing only positive memories. Focus on positive experiences that boost your confidence, and let the bad memories fade over time.
- See people in perspective. Realize that successful people with money, status and power are also human beings with needs, problems and desires. When people seem rude or aggressive, don't treat it as a personal attack—tell yourself that they're actually nice people who're just having a bad day.
- Never act against your conscience or values. The guilt will eat away at you and cause you to lose confidence in yourself.
- Your physical state affects your mental-emotional state and vice versa. When you behave confidently, you'll also feel confident.
 - (i) Sit at the front row during meetings and assemblies;
 - (ii) Make eye contact and give a big smile to others;
 - (iii) Speak up: volunteer your comments, ideas or questions; and
 - (iv) Walk fast with your shoulders back and your head held high.



Think Creatively



Creative thinking is about finding new and better ways to do things. You can apply it to *any* issue or context, e.g. a

KEY QUOTES

"Action cures fear. Indecision, postponement, on the other hand, fertilize fear."

"There is within each of us a desire to be right, think right, and act right. When we go against that desire, we put a cancer in our conscience."

"To think confidently, act confidently."

"Creative thinking is simply finding new, improved ways to do anything."

low-income family finding a way to send their son overseas to study, or an accountant designing a simpler process for book-keeping.



Use these tools/tips to improve your creative thinking:

- Remove the word “impossible” from your vocabulary. If you believe something’s possible, your mind will seek out the solutions. Focus on why something can be done.
- There’s always more than 1 way to achieve a goal. Free yourself from old ways of thinking. Be open to new ideas, experiment with new approaches and look forward (not backward). Continually improve yourself, e.g. have a weekly improvement plan to target specific skills/attitudes, or to test new solutions.
- Your capacity is a reflection of your inner beliefs. To expand your capacity, welcome new opportunities and responsibilities, and ask yourself “How can I do even more?” or “What can I do to increase my output?”
- Get better insights by asking questions and listening:
 - (i) Test an idea by asking “What do you think of this idea?”
 - (ii) Invite others to talk (ask “What do you think we can do about this?” or “Can you tell me more about your experience?”)
 - (iii) Listen actively and process what the other person is saying.
- Inject mental stimulation by:
 - (i) Joining ≥ 1 professional group where you can interact with people *within* your field of work, and ≥ 1 group to meet people *outside* your field of work.
 - (ii) Expanding your depth and range of ideas: Write down your ideas as they surface → Review them regularly → Keep the ideas with value/potential and throw out the rest → Develop your ideas (e.g. think/research about them, and connect them to other related ideas) → At the right time, flesh out an idea on paper → Try to “sell” it to someone to test if it has real value.

KEY QUOTES

“When you believe, your mind finds ways to do.”

“Capacity is a state of mind. How much we can do depends on how much we think we can do.”

“Somebody must ‘buy’ the idea; else it has no value.”



See Yourself in a Better Light



Why do some people emit confidence and command respect, while others don't? The answer lies in their self-image and appearance.

- How you see yourself affects how you look and behave. This shapes others' impression of you and how they respond to you.
- Your appearance also affects how you think and feel. When you're dressed up for a party, you'll be in a "party mood" When you're dressed up as a soldier you start to think and act like one.
- Pay attention to your appearance. You can use the same amount of money to buy half the amount of clothes at double the price, i.e. go for quality over quantity.



Take pride in your work. Three brick-layers were asked about their job. One said that he was laying bricks. The second said he was making money. The third said that he was building the world's greatest cathedral. How would you define what you do?

- When you believe that your work is meaningful and important, you'll put in your best effort, which leads to better results, more money, promotions, status, and fulfillment.
- If you're a leader or manager, your attitudes and behaviors will directly affect your team. Lead by example: demonstrate the type of enthusiasm, can-do attitude and positive behavior that you'd like to see in your team members.



Try giving yourself a pep-talk at the start of each day or just before a challenging task.

- Learn to sell yourself to yourself.
 - (i) List down your best qualities.

KEY QUOTES

"Others see in us what we see in ourselves. We receive the kind of treatment we think we deserve."

(ii) Write a self-promotion commercial, e.g. "David, I'd like you to meet David, who's a really important person. David is..."

(iii) Say this out loud daily with conviction, ideally in front of a mirror. In addition, read this silently whenever you need a confidence-booster.



Upgrade your thinking in all aspects of life. When you get worried or angry, stop to think if this is what an important person would get worried or angry about. Evaluate your appearance, attitude, language, and actions by considering what successful people would do in your shoes.



Create a First-Class Environment



Our physical health is affected by the food we consume. Likewise, our mental health is affected by our environment and mental diet. Our beliefs and habits—from the clothes we wear to the way we greet one another—are shaped by our environment. You'll be a different person today if you had grown up in a different country and culture. Your current environment will in turn shape the person you become in the future.



Improve your social environment: spend time only with people who provide positive mental stimulation.

- Enlarge your social circle by joining new groups or organizations to meet people with different background and experiences. Don't just hang out with friends who share your views, religious or political beliefs. Get to know successful people (or people with potential) and learn how/why they see and do things differently.
- Choose friends who're positive, big-thinkers, and want you to succeed. Stay away from people who constantly gossip, complain about petty issues, speak negatively about others or spread rumors/scandals.



Consciously manage the negative forces around you. We're constantly bombarded by suppressive forces that tell us what we cannot or should not do. Many people simply give up and accept their lot in life. Others may achieve some

KEY QUOTES

"Go first class when you have questions. Seeking advice from a failure is like consulting a quack on how to cure cancer."

success but hold back due to their fear of failure, loss or uncertainty. Only 2-3% of people keep making progress year on year because they refuse to surrender or listen to the naysayers.



Only take advice from the best in class. Seek out people who've achieved the results you wish to achieve and ask for their advice.



Improve your Attitude to Improve your Results

Your attitudes affect how you think, feel and act, to affect your outcomes. If you hold negative attitudes toward something or someone, others can sense it from your body language.



Become activated, so you can infect others with your passion and enthusiasm:

- Dig deeper to learn more about something/someone. You can always uncover interesting facts that spark your interest.
- Inject life into everything you do, be it a handshake, a smile, or a speech. When you put in vigor, feelings and conviction, you'll feel more alive and invigorate others around you.
- Spread good news and positive experiences that uplift everyone (including yourself). Each time you interact with someone, aim to leave him/her feeling better than before they met you.



Every human being wants to feel recognized. Treat everyone like they're important, regardless of their status/role or whether they can do anything for you.

- When you make others feel important, they'll notice you and be more receptive toward you, which makes you feel more important too.
- Visualize people at their best and treat them accordingly.
- Show your appreciation: smile, let people know how you depend on them, and give your sincere compliments.

KEY QUOTES

"Attitudes are mirrors of the mind. They reflect thinking."

"Dig in deeper and you dig up interest."

- Always address people by their name, making sure that you spell and pronounce it correctly.
- Share the credit instead of hogging it. If you receive a praise from your boss, pass it down to your team.
- Give planned attention to your loved ones. Ask yourself daily what you can do to make them happy, and set aside time where you can give them your undivided attention.



The best way to make more money is to put service first. If you give more than what people expect, they'll keep coming back.



Treat People Right



No one can succeed without others' support. Work on being likeable. Remember people's names, be courteous, make others comfortable around you, and use every opportunity to add value or give strength to others.



Take the initiative to make friends. Say nice things to everyone you meet, including strangers. At every possible opportunity, introduce yourself to others. Make sure you get their name right. Pronounce it the way they do, and write it down with the correct spelling. Where possible, get their contact details, and follow up with those whom you want to get to know better.



Accept others' limitations and imperfections. Respect individual differences and resist the urge to correct/reform others.

- When you assume the worst in others, you'll subconsciously dismiss their inputs, and react suspiciously to everything they say and do. Not surprisingly, they'll respond unfavorably to you too.
- Focus on the positive qualities in others. When you see the best in people, they'll also respond positively to you.



It always pays to listen to people, regardless of whether you're trying to understand a customer, solve a problem or win a friend. Encourage others to talk about themselves

KEY QUOTES

"Put service first, and money takes care of itself."

"A person is not pulled up to a higher level job. Rather, he is lifted up."

"Don't be a conversation hog. Listen, win friends, and learn."

(instead of hogging the conversation) and truly listen to what they're saying.



When things go wrong, don't blame others or berate yourself. Focus on how you can do better in future, and make it happen. Set aside your ego to mend any cracks in your relationships.



Take Action Proactively



Ideas alone are useless without action. Don't wait for the perfect plan or conditions before you act.

- You can't avoid risks or challenges. It's better to take the first steps, allow the situation to unfold, and work out the solutions along the way.
- As you take action, you'll overcome your original fears and add value to your ideas. On the other hand, procrastination will only leave you feeling guilty and frustrated.



Don't wait for inspiration before you act. Instead, take action to *generate* inspiration and momentum. Think of your brain like a mechanical system—by turning a few cogs, you can start your mental engine:

- Break down a task into smaller steps and start going through them mechanically. If you need inspiration for a project, start writing or doodling to get your creative juices flowing. If you're struggling to make your sales calls, start by driving out, parking your car, taking your samples, walking to a door, and ringing the bell. Before long, you'll get start to build momentum.
- Practice this approach on unpleasant chores or tasks, then apply it to more intense work, e.g. solving a challenging problem.
- The key is to identify what you can do and take action now.



Take the initiative to do what's right or meaningful, without being told to do so. If you believe something ought to be done, then do it instead of waiting for others. If you're

KEY QUOTES

"Action feeds and strengthens confidence; inaction in all forms feeds fear."

*"Action must precede action.
That's a law of nature."*

interested in a project, then volunteer for it. Don't let your fear of rejection or failure hold you back.



Turn Defeat into Triumph



Successful people don't cruise through life. They too face opposition, setbacks and defeat. However, instead of complaining about their bad fortune, they learn from the experience, overcome the obstacles, and bounce back stronger than before. To bounce back from a defeat:

- See every setback as an opportunity to learn. Do a post-mortem to identify the mistakes, gaps or flaws, and address them without condemning yourself or blaming others.
- Believe there's a solution, then set your mind to find it. However, don't bang yourself against the wall by doing the same thing over and over. Experiment with new solutions and approaches.
- If you're stuck, take a break (e.g. go for a walk, take a nap or a short vacation) and return to the problem with fresh eyes.



Make Progress with Clear, Meaningful Goals



Every major breakthrough started with a vision. A goal is a clear objective that you're working toward. To take purposeful action, you must first get clear on where you want to go:

- Start by visualizing where you want to be in 10 years:
 - (i) *Work*: What level of income, responsibility, authority and status do you wish to achieve?
 - (ii) *Home*: What lifestyle do you want to have, and what financial support do you want to give your children or parents?
 - (iii) *Social*: What type of friends and social groups do you invest your time in, and what causes would you champion?

KEY QUOTES

"Defeat is only a state of mind, and nothing more."

"Before you start out, know where you want to go."

- Define what you want to achieve in life, who you wish to be and what would fulfill you.



Have the courage to follow your desires. When you're doing something you love and believe in, you'll feel energized and inspired, thus increasing your chances of success.

- Beware of these 5 goal-killers: undervaluing your potential, choosing "security" over passion, avoiding a career because it seems too competitive, doing what your parents want you to do, or using family responsibilities as an excuse not to change.



Set big goals, break them down into smaller milestones, then conquer them one step at a time.

- Set goals for 30-day periods, broken down by daily activities. For example, a 30-day self-improvement plan could look like this:
 - (i) Break bad habits (e.g. stop gossiping and using negative language) and build positive habits (e.g. compliment people and set aside time daily to plan your work for the next day).
 - (ii) Increase your value to your employer (e.g. develop your team members and improve work efficiency) and your family (e.g. show appreciation to your spouse/kids).
 - (iii) Build your mental capacity (e.g. read useful books/materials, do quiet reflection daily).
- Be prepared to make detours or take a different route to arrive at your goal.



Be an Effective Leader

No leader can rise or succeed without the support of his/her followers. Master the 4 rules of leadership to become an effective leader.



To influence people, you must first see things from their perspective. Put yourself in their shoes to consider how they

KEY QUOTES

"To get others to do what you want them to do, you must see things through their eyes."

may see things given their background, interests and circumstances. Ask yourself: what would make them *want* to do what you'd like them to do? For example, what would make a customer want to buy your product? What would make a 5 year old kid want to eat his vegetables?



Respect others as fellow human beings. In every decision:

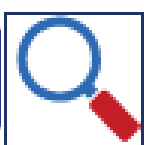
- Ask yourself, “What’s the human way to address this?” For example, during a layoff, an executive took time to explain the situation to each employee and even helped them to set up interviews with potential employers.
- Show that you’re putting their interests first. The best way to win goodwill and loyalty is to be genuinely interested in others’ needs, well-being, and success.



Be progressive in all aspects of your life. Set high standards and seek continual improvement for yourself and others. Treat others the way you’d like to be treated.



Set aside quiet time for solitude, deep thinking and reflection. Commit 1 hour daily to think deeply in a distraction-free space. You can choose to focus on a specific issue or just contemplate whatever issue comes to mind. After a couple of weeks, you may be amazed at how clear and focused your thinking has become.



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book

No matter what challenge you’re facing—whether you’re feeling stuck, discouraged, struggling with a project or relationship—you can conquer it by thinking bigger and becoming a bigger person. However, thinking big is not the same as wishful thinking. Take action *now* to apply the principles above, and observe how successful and unsuccessful people around you embrace or ignore these principles. In the book, Schwartz also shares many personal anecdotes and observations behind the principles in this summary. If you’ve enjoyed the ideas in this summary, do get a copy of the book for more details.

KEY QUOTES

“Rub people the right way. Be human.”

“Think progress, believe in progress, push for progress.”